

Current Affairs 10-10-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

World Development Report 2026: The Promise of Artificial Intelligence



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Union Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology launched the **World Bank Group's World Development Report (WDR) 2026: The Promise of Artificial Intelligence**. The event was organised under the **IndiaAI Mission with the World Bank Group**. The report was first released globally in August 2026.

What are the Key Highlights of the WDR 2026: The Promise of Artificial Intelligence Report?

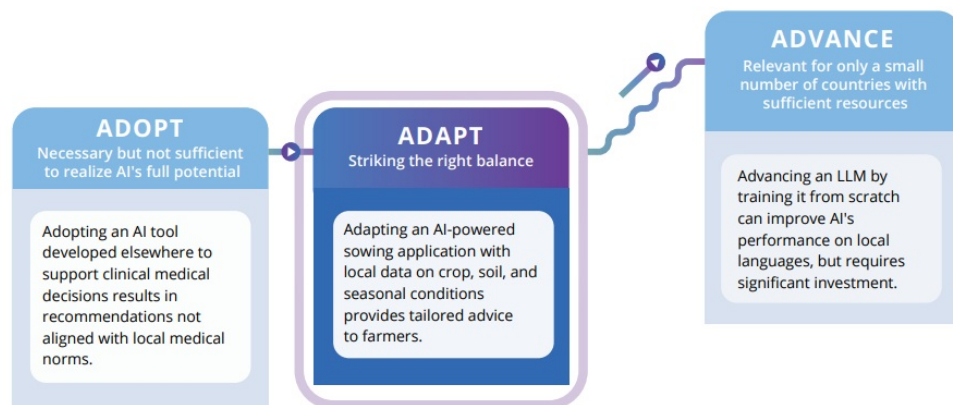
- **Rapid Diffusion vs. The Adoption Gap:** AI is spreading faster than earlier **General-Purpose Technologies (GPTs)**.
 - Steam engines took **80 years**, electricity **40 years**, and the internet **20 years** to reach lower-income economies; **ChatGPT** achieved 50% traffic from middle-income nations within **six months**.
 - By April 2025, ChatGPT adoption reached **25%** among internet users in high-income economies, compared to **5.8%** (upper-middle), **4.7%** (lower-middle), and **0.7%** (low-income).
 - Historic gains belong not necessarily to the inventors of GPTs, but to countries that **quickly build foundational complements and deploy applications at scale**.
- **The Three Cs Deciding AI's Development Value:**
 - **Capabilities:** AI automates non-routine cognitive functions (e.g., disease diagnosis, weather forecasting, farm advisory), bridging acute specialist shortages in developing regions.
 - **Concentration:** Advanced compute, chip design, and frontier models remain concentrated in the **US and China** (with top US tech firms projected to spend over **USD 750 billion** on AI infrastructure in 2026).
 - This creates structural dependency risks while offering cheaper access to pre-trained models.
 - **Complements:** AI cannot function without reliable physical and institutional foundations.
 - In Sub-Saharan Africa, **32%** of rural schools lack electricity, **68%** lack internet, and **89%** of 10-year-olds struggle with foundational reading (2024).
- **"Small AI" in Low-Resource Settings:** Compact, low-compute models drive cost-effective public delivery in developing nations proven by **Wadhvani AI's "Cough Against TB"** in India (90% screening

- accuracy) and the **Rori learning platform** in Ghana (delivering a full year of educational gains at ~\$5 per student).
- **Economic & Labor Market Impact:** While generative AI threatens automation for only **4.5% of jobs in developing countries** (vs. **14.2% in high-income economies**), productivity gains remain skewed toward advanced nations.
 - Meanwhile, **outsourced BPO (Business Process Outsourcing) gigs fell 39% in 2025**, and **domestic data centers** increasingly stress local power and water grids.
 - **Governance & Social Delivery:** AI delivers measurable public sector gains such as **Kenya's court case allocation** (10,000+ disputes), **India's agricultural forecasting**, and a **40% rise in daily diabetic eye screenings in Bangladesh** though misaligned tools like failed automated cash transfers expose persistent data risks.
 - In India, AI weather forecasts produced savings of as much as USD 560 per small farmer in the state of Telangana.
 - **Geopolitics & Information Integrity:** Because full **domestic AI sovereignty** is cost-prohibitive, developing nations require open-source models and regional compute sharing to counter severe **capital-labor wage disparities** (e.g., Kenyan data labellers earning 1.32–2.00/hour) and acute **disinformation risks** where Africa has only 66 fact-checking bodies for 1.5 billion people.
 - **The Global Preparedness Gap:** Over **80 countries** had released national AI strategies by mid-2026, yet **Rwanda** remains the **solitary low-income nation out of 25 to establish an official policy framework**, leaving the most vulnerable economies structurally unready.

What are the Key Recommendations of the WDR 2026: The Promise of Artificial Intelligence Report?

- **Follow the "Adopt, Adapt, Advance" Ladder:**
 - **Adopt Off-the-Shelf Tools as a Starting Point:** Leverage existing open-source and commercial AI applications to resolve immediate bottlenecks (e.g., administrative triage, basic translation), recognizing that adoption alone is necessary but insufficient.
 - **Prioritize "Adaptation" for Maximum Development Dividends:** Focus resources on tailoring models to local languages, agro-climatic conditions, and domestic healthcare protocols (preventing misdiagnoses caused by Western-trained data).
 - Design **multimodal solutions** that function on low-cost technologies (such as voice-based applications over basic 2G/feature phones) to ensure digital inclusion.
 - **Be Pragmatic on "Advancing" Frontier AI:** Avoid costly attempts to build frontier foundation models from scratch, which require billions in compute and massive energy grids. Instead, focus on **"Small AI."**
- **Governments as Enablers :** Governments should **strengthen AI-ready foundations** through **reliable electricity, affordable broadband, digital literacy and foundational education**, while democratizing access to **compute and quality public datasets** through **Compute-as-a-Service** and open data repositories.
 - **Labour and tax policies** must also prevent **premature job displacement due to AI automation**.
- **Governments as Users:** Governments should move beyond fragmented **AI pilot projects** towards **evaluated and scalable solutions**. **Public procurement** can help test and scale **domestic AI applications** in agriculture, healthcare, education and social protection.

- **Standardized, clean and AI-ready government data integrated with Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)** can improve public service delivery.
- **Governments as Regulators:** Governments should adopt **agile, risk-based AI regulation** , beginning with **voluntary standards, algorithmic impact assessments and third-party audits** .
 - Existing **consumer protection, competition, data protection and cyber laws** should be enforced against **AI-enabled fraud, deepfakes and algorithmic discrimination** , while **international regulatory coordination** can ensure **cross-border interoperability** and reduce regulatory fragmentation.
- **Mitigate Structural Inequality:** Promote **regional compute infrastructure** through shared computing clusters and multilateral partnerships, while ensuring **fair wages and labour protections** for AI data-annotation and content-moderation workers.
 - Also strengthen **digital media literacy, fact-checking and synthetic-media watermarking** to counter **AI-driven disinformation** and protect institutional trust.



Source: WDR 2026 team.

Note: AI = artificial intelligence; LLM = large language model.

Conclusion

The **World Development Report 2026** stresses that AI can drive development only when supported by **infrastructure, skills, data and strong institutions** . Developing countries should **adopt, adapt and advance AI** without succumbing to hype or fear. For **India** , key priorities include leveraging **DPI** while addressing **job displacement, sovereign AI costs and data-centre fiscal risks** .

Drishti Mains Question:

Explain the significance of the 'Adopt, Adapt and Advance' approach for developing countries seeking to harness Artificial Intelligence for development.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the World Development Report 2026?

It is the **World Bank Group's flagship report on Artificial Intelligence and development** , examining how developing countries can use AI for **economic growth, productivity and public service delivery** .

2. What are the Three Cs of AI development?

The Three Cs are **Capabilities, Concentration and Complements** , highlighting AI's potential, the concentration of AI resources and the foundational conditions required for effective adoption.

3. What is the 'Adopt, Adapt and Advance' approach?

It recommends that developing countries first **adopt existing AI tools** , then **adapt them to local needs** , and selectively **advance AI capabilities** where they have strategic advantages.

4. What is Small AI?

Small AI refers to **compact, low-compute AI models** designed for specific applications, making them more affordable and practical for developing countries.

5. What are the major AI challenges for developing countries?

Key challenges include **digital infrastructure gaps, limited skills and data, job displacement, technological concentration, inequality and AI-driven disinformation** .

6. How can governments promote AI development?

Governments should strengthen **electricity, broadband, digital skills and AI-ready public data** , while using **public procurement and risk-based regulation** to scale responsible AI applications.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/hfXyDIsRdCQ>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With the present state of development, Artificial Intelligence can effectively do which of the following? (2020)

1. Bring down electricity consumption in industrial units
2. Create meaningful short stories and songs
3. Disease diagnosis
4. Text-to-Speech Conversion
5. Wireless transmission of electrical energy

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2, 3 and 5 only
- (b) 1, 3 and 4 only
- (c) 2, 4 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. What are the main socio-economic implications arising out of the development of IT industries in major cities of India? (2022)

Q. “The emergence of the Fourth Industrial Revolution (Digital Revolution) has initiated e-Governance as an integral part of government”. Discuss. (2020)

Centenary of the Union Public Service Commission



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Union Public Service Commission (UPSC)** completed **100 years on 1st October 2026** ,

What are the Key Facts About UPSC?

- **About:** The **Union Public Service Commission (UPSC)** is an **independent constitutional body** responsible for recruitment to the **All India Services** and **various Central Services** , ensuring merit, impartiality and equal opportunity in public appointments.
 - It functions as India's principal central recruitment agency and is headquartered at **Dholpur House, New Delhi** .
 - The UPSC consists of a **Chairman and other Members** , all appointed by the **President of India** .
- **Constitutional Provisions:** The UPSC derives its constitutional status from **Part XIV (Articles 315-323)** of the Constitution.

Article	Provision
315	Provides for Public Service Commissions for the Union and States , including a Joint Commission for two or more States .
316	Provides for the appointment of the Chairman and Members of the Commission by the President .
317	Provides for removal or suspension of Members by the President, subject to the prescribed constitutional procedure, including Supreme Court inquiry .
318	Empowers the appropriate authority to make regulations regarding the conditions of service of Members and staff .
319	Provides restrictions on further employment after ceasing to be a Member of the Commission.
320	Specifies the Commission’s functions, including conducting examinations and advising on recruitment, appointments, promotions and disciplinary matters .
321	Enables Parliament or a State Legislature to extend the functions of the Commission.
322	Provides that the expenses of the Commission are charged on the Consolidated Fund of the respective government.
323	Requires the Commission to submit an annual report to the President or Governor, including cases where its advice was not accepted and the reasons for such non-acceptance.

- **Key Functions:**
 - **Recruitment through Examinations:** Conducts examinations such as the **Civil Services**

Examination (CSE), Indian Forest Service (IFoS), Engineering Services, Combined Medical Services, NDA & NA, CDS and CAPF (Assistant Commandants) examinations.

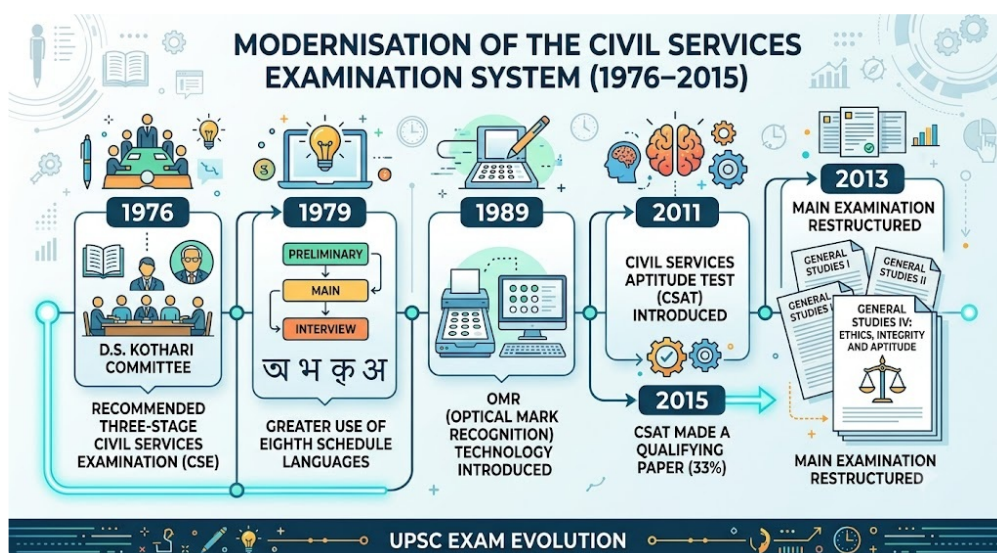
- **Direct Recruitment:** Conducts recruitment tests and interviews for specialised posts in Union Ministries and Departments.
- **Advisory Role:** Advises the government on **recruitment rules, appointments, promotions, disciplinary matters and induction into All India Services** .
- **Police Leadership:** Empanels senior IPS officers for appointment as **Director General of Police (DGP) /Head of Police Force** in States, following the Supreme Court's directions in **Prakash Singh v. Union of India (2006)** .
- **Institutional Independence:** UPSC's autonomy is safeguarded through **constitutional protection of tenure, regulated removal procedures, restrictions on post-tenure employment and financial provisions** .
 - These safeguards seek to protect the recruitment process against **political interference, favouritism and nepotism** .
- **Scale and Representation:** The Commission conducts around **14-15 major examinations** and handles over **250 recruitment processes** .
 - Women's representation among candidates recommended through CSE increased from **3.6% in 1952 to 31.2% in 2025** , reflecting greater participation in public services.
 - **In 2021**, women appeared in the **NDA & NA Examination** for the first time.

How Has UPSC Evolved Over the Last Century?

- **Introduction of Competitive Recruitment (1855):** The **Indian Civil Service (ICS) examination** was introduced in London, replacing the East India Company's nomination-based system with open competition.
 - However, the examination was conducted only in **London and in English** , with subjects such as Greek and Latin, restricting Indian participation.
- **Entry of Indians into the ICS:** **Satyendranath Tagore** became the **first Indian ICS officer** in **1864** , after clearing the examination in 1863.
 - By **1919** , only **78 of 1,255 ICS officers** were Indians, reflecting limited access under colonial rule.
- **Demand for a Public Service Commission (1919-1924):**
 - The **Government of India Act, 1919** , based on the **Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms** , provided for establishing a Public Service Commission.
 - In **1922** , the ICS examination was conducted in India for the first time at **Allahabad** , alongside London.
 - The **Lee Commission (1924)** , chaired by **Arthur Hamilton Lee** , recommended the immediate establishment of a statutory Public Service Commission and greater Indian representation.
- **Establishment of the First Public Service Commission (1926):** India's first Public Service Commission was established on **1st October 1926** under the **Public Service Commission (Functions) Rules, 1926** , framed under Sections 96B and 96C of the Government of India Act, 1919.
 - **Sir Ross Barker** was its first Chairman, assisted by four Members, and the Commission was initially housed at **Metcalf House, Delhi** .
 - Although primarily **advisory with limited powers** , it marked the beginning of permanent institutionalised public-service recruitment in India.
- **Transition to the Federal Public Service Commission (1937):** The **Government of India Act,**

1935 strengthened the institutional framework and provided for Federal and Provincial Public Service Commissions.

- On **1st April 1937** , the Commission became the **Federal Public Service Commission** .
- **Combined competitive examinations** for multiple services began in **1938** , while **H.K. Kripalani** became its first Indian Chairman in **1947** .
- **Emergence of Constitutional UPSC (1950):** On **26th January 1950** , the Federal Public Service Commission became the **Union Public Service Commission** , with **R.N. Banerjee** as Chairman.
 - The Constitution granted UPSC **independent constitutional status** , with safeguards to ensure merit-based and impartial recruitment.
- **Expanding Inclusion and Accessibility:**
 - **1992: Rose Millian Bathew Kharbuli** became UPSC's **first woman Chairperson** .
 - **1994:** Scribes were introduced for visually impaired candidates, followed by wider accessibility provisions for eligible candidates with disabilities.
- **Digital Modernisation (2025-2026):** UPSC introduced the **Universal Registration Number** , randomised interview boards and **Pratibha Setu** in 2025. In 2026, it implemented **AI-enabled facial authentication** for approximately **5.50 lakh candidates** during the Civil Services Preliminary Examination to strengthen examination security.



Interesting Facts About UPSC

- **Civil Services Day:** On **21st April 1947** , [Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel](#) addressed the first batch of civil service probationers at **Metcalf House, Delhi** , describing the civil services as the **“steel frame of India”** . The date is observed annually as **Civil Services Day** .
- **UPSC Headquarters: Dholpur House** , built in 1920 by Maharaja Rana Udaybhanu Singh of Dholpur, became UPSC's **permanent headquarters in 1952** .
- **Draft Constitution:** The provisions concerning Public Service Commissions were initially numbered **Articles 284 and 285** when introduced by [Dr. B.R. Ambedkar](#) in the Constituent Assembly. They subsequently became **Articles 315-323** of the Constitution.
- **UPSC Museum:** Established on **11th November 2016** , the museum showcases the Commission's institutional history and offers a **360-degree virtual tour** .

Conclusion

UPSC's centenary reflects India's transition from **colonial-era recruitment to an independent constitutional system** rooted in merit, impartiality and equal opportunity. As governance challenges evolve, UPSC must balance its institutional independence and examination integrity with **competency-based recruitment, technological innovation, transparency and aspirant well-being** to build a capable, inclusive and future-ready civil service.

“An institution that has endured for a hundred years does so not because it resists change, but because it knows what must never change.”

— Dr. Ajay Kumar, Chairman, UPSC

Drishti Mains Practice Question

The evolution of the Union Public Service Commission reflects the institutionalisation of merit, fairness and inclusion in India's public services. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. When was the first Public Service Commission established in India?

The first Public Service Commission was established on **1 October 1926**.

Q2. When did UPSC become a constitutional body?

The Federal Public Service Commission became the **Union Public Service Commission on 26 January 1950** under the Constitution.

Q3. Which Articles of the Constitution deal with Public Service Commissions?

Public Service Commissions are covered under **Articles 315-323 in Part XIV** of the Constitution.

Q4. Who appoints the Chairman and Members of UPSC?

The **President of India** appoints the Chairman and Members of UPSC under Article 316.

Q5. What are the major functions of UPSC?

UPSC conducts examinations for recruitment to various Union services and advises the Government on recruitment rules, promotions, disciplinary matters and other service-related issues.

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. Identify ten essential values that are needed to be an effective public servant. Describe the ways and means to prevent non-ethical behavior in the public servants. **(2021)**

Q. “Institutional quality is a crucial driver of economic performance”. In this context suggest reforms in the Civil Service for strengthening democracy. **(2020)**

India-EU Green Shipping Corridor



Source: ET

Why in News?

India and the **European Union (EU)** formally launched an industry coalition for the **India-EU Green Shipping Corridor** at the **3rd edition of Sagarmanthan: The Great Oceans Dialogue (2026)** to accelerate the adoption of low-emission maritime fuels, mobilise investment and develop commercially viable green shipping routes.

- The **Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW)** organised the dialogue in partnership with the **Observer Research Foundation (ORF)** .

What are the Key Highlights of the India-EU Green Shipping Corridor Initiative?

- **Green Fuel Trade:** The initiative seeks to connect India's green fuel production potential with growing European demand, facilitating trade in **green ammonia** and **methanol** and accelerating maritime decarbonisation.
- **Implementation Roadmap:** Following the launch of a **pre-feasibility study in 2025** , an industry coalition was established in 2026 to mobilise private investment, strengthen government-industry partnerships and develop a commercially viable and scalable green shipping corridor.
- **Renewable Energy at Ports:** Under the **Harit Sagar Green Port Guidelines, 2023** , India aims to increase the share of renewable energy in major ports' overall energy consumption to **over 60% by 2030 and over 90% by 2047** .
- **Green Maritime Transition:** Diesel-powered harbour tugs are being progressively replaced with green-powered vessels, while **Deendayal Port (Gujarat)**, **Paradip Port (Odisha)** and **V.O. Chidambaranar Port (Tamil Nadu)** have been identified as **green hydrogen** hubs for the production, storage and bunkering of cleaner maritime fuels.
 - India's broader green-port strategy also promotes shore-to-ship electricity, electrification of port equipment and vehicles, and reductions in carbon emissions from port operations.
- **Maritime Resilience:** The initiative seeks to **strengthen maritime supply-chain resilience** against geopolitical disruptions and climate-related risks while supporting a just and inclusive green transition.
- **Port Capacity Expansion:** Under the **Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047** , India aims to expand its annual port-handling capacity to **10 billion tonnes by 2047** .
 - Major ports handled **over 915 million tonnes of cargo in FY 2025-26** , compared with **581 million tonnes in FY 2014-15** .
- **National Waterways:** Cargo movement on national waterways increased from **18 million tonnes in FY 2013-14 to 218 million tonnes in FY 2025-26** , highlighting the growing role of inland waterways in India's multimodal transport system.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the India-EU Green Shipping Corridor Initiative?

The India-EU Green Shipping Corridor Initiative aims to establish low-emission maritime trade routes between India and the European Union by promoting cleaner shipping fuels, mobilising private investment and strengthening sustainable maritime connectivity.

2. Where was the India-EU Green Shipping Corridor Industry Coalition launched?

The coalition was launched at the 3rd edition of Sagarmathan: The Great Oceans Dialogue (2026), organised by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW) in partnership with the Observer Research Foundation (ORF).

3. Which alternative fuels are being promoted under the India-EU Green Shipping Corridor?

The initiative promotes low-emission maritime fuels, particularly green ammonia and green methanol, by connecting India's green fuel production potential with growing European demand.

4. What are India's renewable energy targets under the Harit Sagar Green Port Guidelines, 2023?

India aims to increase renewable energy's share in the overall energy consumption of major ports to over 60% by 2030 and over 90% by 2047.

5. Which Indian ports have been identified as green hydrogen hubs?

Deendayal Port (Gujarat), Paradip Port (Odisha) and V.O. Chidambaranar Port (Tamil Nadu) have been identified as green hydrogen hubs to support the production, storage and bunkering of cleaner maritime fuels.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/PonnOubX-eU>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Which of the following statements with regard to Green Hydrogen is/are correct ? (2025)

1. It is decarbonized hydrogen obtained from natural gas reforming combined with carbon capture and storage (CCS).
2. It is produced using electrolysis of water with electricity generated by renewable energy.
3. National Green Hydrogen Mission of India aims for an abatement of nearly 50 MMT of annual greenhouse gas emissions by 2030.

Select the answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 2 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: B

Q. Consider the following heavy industries: (2023)

1. Fertilizer plants
2. Oil refineries
3. Steel plants

Green hydrogen is expected to play a significant role in decarbonizing how many of the above industries?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

Ans: (c)

Q. With reference to green hydrogen, consider the following statements : (2023)

1. It can be used directly as a fuel for internal combustion.
2. It can be blended with natural gas and used as fuel for heat or power generation.
3. It can be used in the hydrogen fuel cell to run vehicles.

How many of the above statements are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

Ans: (c)

Q. Hydrogen fuel cell vehicles produce one of the following as “exhaust” (2010)

- (a) NH_3
- (b) CH_4
- (c) H_2O
- (d) H_2O_2

Ans: (c)

1st-Ever WHO Guidelines on Child and Adolescent Obesity



Source: IE

The **World Health Organization (WHO)** has released its first-ever clinical guidelines on managing **pediatric and adolescent obesity** , setting an age-differentiated protocol that prohibits weight-loss pharmacotherapy and bariatric surgery for children under nine while permitting restricted, conditional medical interventions for adolescents aged 10 to 19.

- **Age-Specific Mandates:**

- **Children aged 0-9 years:** The guidelines **strongly advise against anti-obesity drugs** (including **GLP-1 receptor agonists**) and **bariatric surgeries** (e.g., gastric bypass), mandating **family-centered behavioral modifications, structured nutrition, and physical activity** as the sole standard of care.
- **Adolescents aged 10-19 years:** Approved anti-obesity medicines may be considered only when a supervised multimodal lifestyle programme fails to achieve the desired results.
 - Bariatric surgery may be considered under strict conditions for adolescents with severe obesity.
- **Rationale for Pharmacotherapy Restrictions:** The WHO noted an absence of **long-term clinical trial data** regarding the pediatric safety, efficacy, treatment duration, and tapering protocols of anti-obesity drugs like [semaglutide](#) .
- **Integrated Mental Healthcare:** Obesity management should address associated psychological challenges, including anxiety, depression, low self-esteem, stigma and bullying, through family-engaged and age-appropriate care.
- **Promotion of Digital Health Interventions:** Recommends the conditional adoption of **active video games (exergames - encourage bodily movement as part of gameplay)** , pedometers, accelerometers, and fitness applications to replace **sedentary screen time** with active movement.
- **Global Pediatric Obesity Burden:** As of 2024, **170 million children and adolescents (ages 5-19)** live with obesity globally (comprising **70 million children (ages 5-9)** and **100 million adolescents (ages 10-19)**), with the fastest acceleration occurring in **Low- and Middle-Income Countries (LMICs)** .
- **India-Specific Epidemiology:** According to a **Lancet study** , obese boys in India surged from 0.2 million in 1990 to **7.3 million in 2022** , while obese girls increased from 0.2 million to **5.2 million** .
 - The **Comprehensive National Nutrition Survey (CNNS)** projects India will house over **27 million obese youth (ages 5-19)** , accounting for **11% of the global burden** , compounding the nation's **dual burden of malnutrition** .
- **Indian Regulatory & Clinical Context:** The [Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation \(CDSCO\)](#) has approved **semaglutide for adolescents aged 12 and above** strictly for morbid obesity with associated comorbidities like **non-alcoholic fatty liver disease (NAFLD)** and prediabetes.
 - Medical consensus cautions that pediatric bariatric surgery carries severe risks of **micronutrient malabsorption and impaired physiological growth** .

Read more: [World Obesity Atlas 2026](#)

DRDO Successfully Tests High Altitude Platform System



Source: TH

The **Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO)** successfully flight-tested an indigenously developed **High-Altitude Platform System (HAPS)** , marking progress towards a **long-endurance stratospheric surveillance platform** .

- **About HAPS:** A High-Altitude Platform Station (HAPS) is a **station carried by an aerial platform, such as an unmanned aircraft, airship or balloon** , operating in the stratosphere.
 - The **International Telecommunication Union (ITU)** defines HAPS as stations located on objects at altitudes of 20-50 km, positioned at specified points relative to Earth.
- **Altitude:** The experimental platform reached **21 km above mean sea level** and remained at **20 km for over 30 minutes** .
- **Developer:** The **Aerial Delivery Research and Development Establishment (ADRDE)**, Agra, a DRDO laboratory, developed the lighter-than-air platform for sustained stratospheric operations.
- **Technology:** The platform carried an **Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU)**, **GPS receiver, onboard cameras and an altitude-control mechanism** for navigation, monitoring and control.
- **Real-Time Monitoring:** Video footage and flight parameters were continuously transmitted to the **Ground Control Station** , demonstrating the intended flight performance.
- **Trial and Recovery:** The platform was commanded to descend and **successfully recovered** , with flight-performance data subsequently analysed for further development.
- **Institutional Coordination:** The trial involved the **Indian Air Force (IAF)**, **Centre for Military Airworthiness and Certification (CEMILAC)**, **Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA)**, **Airports Authority of India (AAI)** and other civil authorities.
- **Strategic Significance:** HAPS can bridge the operational gap between **aircraft and satellites** , enabling persistent **surveillance, intelligence gathering, Earth observation, communications and disaster response** .
 - Its **recoverability for maintenance and upgrades** enhances operational flexibility while strengthening indigenous aerospace capabilities under **Aatmanirbhar Bharat** .

Read More: [DRDO to Transfer Missile Technology to Indian Defence Industry](#)

National PNG Drive 3.0



Source: TH

The **Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB)** on its 20th Foundation Day (1st October 2026) launched the **National PNG Drive 3.0** to accelerate the nationwide transition from **Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) to Piped Natural Gas (PNG)**, aligning with India's broader energy security and sustainability goals.

- **Primary Targets (FY 2027):** The initiative aims to add **50 lakh new domestic-PNG (D-PNG) connections**, convert **40 lakh unbilled connections into active users**, and register an additional 50 lakh users.
 - Under **PNG Drive 2.0 (January - June 2026)**, the government achieved **12.10 lakh new DPNG connections, 13.37 lakh billed connections and 15.31 lakh DPNG registrations**.
- **Energy Security and Sustainability:** PNG supports increasing natural gas's share in India's primary energy mix from around 6%, promoting cleaner-burning fuels, diversified energy access and reliable household energy supply.
- **Environmental & Climate Goals:** The shift towards cleaner fuels directly aligns with India's **net-zero commitments** and **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)** by increasing the share of natural gas in the national energy basket.
- **Geopolitical Catalyst:** The transition to PNG gained momentum during the **West Asia crisis** to reduce reliance on LPG, as LPG supplies are highly vulnerable to disruptions along critical maritime choke points like the **Strait of Hormuz**.
- **Government Policy Incentives:** To spur expansion, the Petroleum Ministry is incentivizing City-Gas Distributors (CGDs) by allocating an **additional 200 standard cubic metres (SCM) of lower-priced Administered Price Mechanism (APM) natural gas** for every incremental billed D-PNG connection.
- **Infrastructure Optimization:** The drive focuses on the gasification and maximum utilization of India's existing **6.9 lakh inch-kms of laid pipeline**, which has the capacity to cater to 1.3 crore additional connections.
- **Key Learnings from Drive 2.0:** The previous drive identified a critical gap between **connected and billed users**, highlighting the need for localized strategies.
 - Focusing on **affordability and awareness in emerging geographical areas (GAs)** and service-level engagement in mature markets.

Read more: [Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board \(PNGRB\)](#)

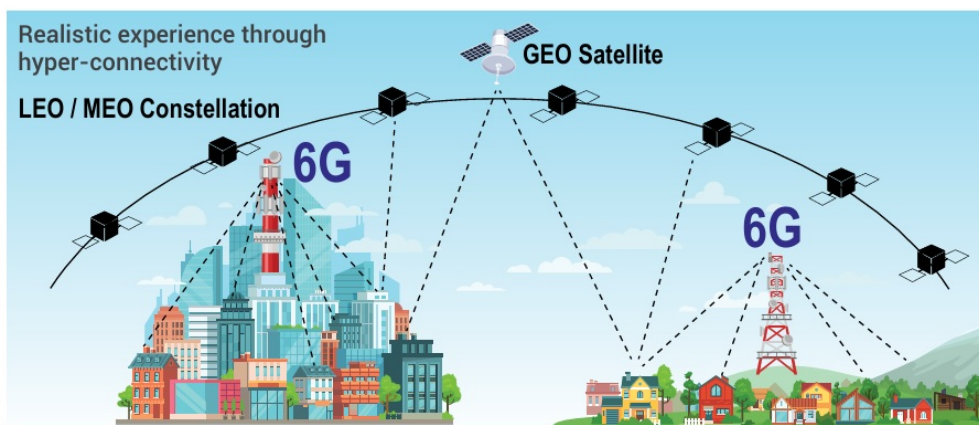
3rd International Bharat 6G Symposium 2026



Source: PIB

The **3rd International Bharat 6G Symposium 2026** was inaugurated by the Union Minister for Communications in **New Delhi**.

- **About Symposium:** Organised by the **Bharat 6G Alliance (B6GA)** , it brings together governments, industry, academia and global technology alliances to advance **6G development** .
 - B6GA signed **5 Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs)** with **GSMA, one6G Association, GTI Alliance, 6G Industry Forum and VoICE** .
- **Key Highlight:** A **joint report** was released to mark one year of progress since the **New Delhi Declaration** was adopted at the **International Bharat 6G Symposium 2025**.
 - The report promotes **secure, open, interoperable, inclusive and sustainable 6G** through global cooperation.
- **Bharat 6G Vision:** Launched in **2023** , it aims to make India a **front-line contributor in the design, development and deployment of 6G technology by 2030**.
 - India is building a **6G-ready ecosystem** under this vision through indigenous research, startup support and industry-academia collaboration, via:
 - **100 Fifth-Generation (5G) Labs:** Promote telecom research, experimentation and skill development.
 - **Telecom Technology Development Fund (TTDF):** Supports indigenous research and development in telecom technologies, including 5G and 6G.
 - **Bharat 6G Alliance:** Brings together **industry, telecom providers, academia and research institutions** to promote **indigenous 6G R&D** and build a globally competitive ecosystem.
- **Global Initiatives on 6G :**
 - **North America:** NextG Alliance
 - **Europe :** 6G IA
 - **China:** IMT 2030PG initiative Future Forum



Read More: [Bharat 6G Vision](#)

